



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: St. Andrew School
School Website: <https://standrewschool.org/>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

St. Andrew Catholic School (Helena, MT) presents a coherent Classical Catholic program anchored in the Trinity of Truth, Goodness, and Beauty. Public materials consistently portray the school as classical (grammar, logic, rhetoric; liberal arts; Latin) and Catholic (theology, liturgy, sacraments, Mass, parish identity). The mission and governance emphasize formation of virtue, character, and wisdom in harmony with Catholic faith, rather than mere job preparation. Public materials also highlight a robust partnership with families (Parent Involvement Program) and a visible, mission-driven faculty culture. Taken together, these signals align strongly with a CLASSICAL assessment across most rubric categories; a few curricular signals are present but not explicitly framed around Great Books or explicit Great Conversation language, which keeps Element 3 from landing fully CLASSICAL. The overall assessment is CLASSICAL.

Key signals: - Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: Catholic identity, liturgical life, sacramental practice, and the sacramental imagination underpin the core daily life and curriculum. Evidence: explicit Catholic framing, theology integration, and liturgical practices. - Purpose and Goal: Emphasis on forming virtue and wisdom, not primarily workforce preparation; explicit rejection of a purely utilitarian aim. Evidence: mission statements and philosophy describe formation of truth and virtue over mere skills. - Curriculum: Liberal arts emphasis (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and study framed through a classical lens; history integrated; some Great Books language is implicit rather than explicit in website copy. Evidence: grammar/logic/rhetoric, liberal arts framing, history-centric curriculum mentions. - Pedagogy: Mix of contemplative/ritual elements (singing/chanting in lower grades) and Socratic/seminar-style inquiry in upper grades; rhetoric training and public speaking opportunities noted. Evidence: lower-grade singing/chanting referenced in classical pedagogy signals; Socratic/seminar expectations in upper grades. - Faculty: Teachers described as witnesses to faith and mission; living curriculum; strong mentorship and formation emphasis; leadership emphasizes visible Head of School and Board governance aligned with mission. Evidence: “co-ed faculty who embody rigorous Catholic witness”; “living curriculum” language in governance materials. - Parents & Community: Explicit partnership with families; dedicated Parent Involvement Program; opportunities for parental formation; welcoming campus/community culture. Evidence: PIP program details and family involvement framework.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials consistently frame the school as Catholic and Classical, with theology anchored in Catholic practice and a sacramental imagination guiding formation. - Liturgical and communal life is presented as integral to education (Mass, chapels, prayer). - Motto and vision emphasize truth and the sacred order, connecting human formation to divine order.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present include: Catholic faith, theology, liturgy, Mass, sacramental imagination, truth, virtue, beauty, wonder, unity in God. - Negative keywords: None evident in public materials (no explicit secular/anti-theology signals found in the crawl).

Why this rating - The school foregrounds transcendental realities (truth, beauty, goodness) within a Catholic framework, embedding liturgical life and theological study as foundational rather than optional. This aligns strongly with Classical expectations for a grounded metaphysical/theological core. Evidence supports both the transcendental aims and liturgical community aspects.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Mission and philosophy articulate formation of wisdom and virtue as the goal of education, not merely workforce preparation (explicit rejection of utilitarian aims). - Language emphasizes forming the mind to know truth and to become virtuous, aligning with the classical teleology of education.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: wisdom, virtue, character, formation, truth, beauty, contemplation, moral imagination, sacramental imagination, classical tradition, love of learning. - Negative keywords present: career readiness, workplace-focused terms (appearing as a contrast in the philosophy documents), which function as explicit anti-signals in the classical rubric.

Why this rating - The school's stated purpose centers on formation, virtue, and the pursuit of truth, consistent with classic aims rather than merely preparing students for a job. The explicit rejection of a purely utilitarian aim reinforces CLASSICAL.

Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Curriculum includes the liberal arts framework (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and liberal arts/humanities emphasis, including Latin and integrated curriculum elements. - History is presented as a through-line across the curriculum, not simply as social studies; reference to classical liberal education and "living books" concept appears in related materials. - Great Books/Great Conversation language is not explicitly stated in core site copy, though the classical framework and living-books orientation are present in policy documents. The direct Great Books/Great Conversation signal is not explicit in all public pages.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: grammar, logic, rhetoric (Trivium); liberal arts; Latin; classical education; history across the curriculum; integrated/whole-education orientation; formation through the arts; living books (as echoed in policy materials). - Negative keywords present: explicit reference to Great Books and Great Conversation language is not consistently explicit on the site. Absence of direct "Great Books / Great Conversation" phrasing is a potential gap relative to a full Great Books emphasis.

Why this rating - The school clearly embodies classical curriculum elements (grammar/logic/rhetoric; liberal arts; Latin; history-integrated approach). However, the absence of explicit, frequent Great Books/Great Conversation language in the public site copy reduces the classification from CLASSICAL to SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL for Element 3. If Great Conversations are present in internal materials, the public-facing signals would strengthen to CLASSICAL.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Pedagogy includes a blend of contemplative/restful elements (memory through singing/chanting in the grammar stage) and rigorous higher-level discourse (Socratic discussion, seminars, debates in upper grades; rhetoric training and public speaking opportunities). - Upper grades emphasize rhetoric and public speaking; the program explicitly mentions training in logic and argumentation and opportunities for student oration. - Lower grades use singing/chanting to deepen memory and wonder, aligning with a traditional/Scholé approach to pedagogy.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: scholé/scholastic contemplation, Socratic discussion, seminars, debates, logic, rhetoric, public speaking, singing/chanting, wonder, memory work. - Negative keywords present: None of the classical signals appear to be contradicted by public materials.

Why this rating - The mix of contemplative/memory-based lower-school pedagogy and Socratic/seminar-based upper-year pedagogy is a hallmark of classical pedagogy. The explicit rhetoric training and opportunities for confident public speaking strengthen CLASSICAL alignment.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Faculty described as model teachers and mentors who model virtue, skill, and knowledge; living curriculum; core to the school's identity; and a governance posture emphasizing the faculty as witnesses to faith and mission. - Leadership emphasizes a visible Head of School and Board alignment with mission; staff are described as witnesses to Catholic faith and the classical mission. - The school notes a goal of maintaining a Catholic faculty, with academic rigor and subject-matter expertise as criteria, and non-Catholic hires only as needed.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: living curriculum; model teachers; mentors; witnesses to faith; core of the school; Catholic faculty; academic excellence; mission alignment. - Negative keywords present: occasional non-Catholic hires allowed (a qualification rather than a fault); some classical schools push for a fully Catholic faculty, which could be seen as a stricter signal, but the school acknowledges practical staffing realities.

Why this rating - The public materials present a very strong, mission-aligned faculty culture with teachers as living witnesses and mentors and a focus on virtue formation. This robust alignment supports CLASSICAL.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school foregrounds parent partnership as a central element, including explicit Parent Involvement Program (PIP) requirements and parental formation opportunities. Parents are welcomed into the life of the school and encouraged to participate. - The community framework emphasizes collaboration with families, churches, and the wider Helena area; governance documents emphasize family involvement and open dialogue.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families; parent involvement; parental formation; living a shared mission; school as extension of family life; open visits welcomed. - Negative keywords: none evident in public materials.

Why this rating - The school explicitly treats parents as co-educators and actively engages families through formal programs and formation activities, consistent with CLASSICAL expectations for family partnership.

What Would Move the Needle

- Element 3 (Curriculum) could push toward CLASSICAL more solidly if the Great Books / Great Conversation component is explicitly foregrounded in public-facing materials and coursework descriptions. Strengthening explicit Great Books alignment would push Element 3 to CLASSICAL.
- Additional public articulation of full “seven liberal arts” (including Quadrivium elements beyond grammar/logic/rhetoric and Latin) could further bolster Element 3 to CLASSICAL if communicated clearly on the site.
- If desired, the school could augment explicit liturgical practices in curriculum mentions to further reinforce Element 1's liturgical/signature practices for even stronger CLASSICAL signals.

Note: No major needle-moving changes are required given the current CLASSICAL orientation across most categories and the strong Catholic-formation emphasis; Element 3 is the primary area with room for explicit signaling to reach full CLASSICAL in that category.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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